

Chapter 16-1

Liang Shi drove back to the hospital.

As soon as she returned, Qiu Zimin called.

"Ah Shi." Qiu Zimin sounded somewhat serious, but calling her by her pet name still seemed affectionate, "Did you meet Zhou Yi'an?"

Liang Shi leaned against the wall, her back feeling the cold.

The lights in the hospital room were off, and the interior was completely dim.

She lightly pressed her lips together, her voice also very quiet, with a slight obscurity, "I met her."

"How did it feel?" Qiu Zimin asked, then continued without waiting for an answer, "You should also divorce that person from the Xu family. She's just a sickly person, and not even the Xu family's biological child. For her sake, our family has already invested seventy to eighty million—that's not a small amount. But your parents love you, and since you liked her before, we didn't say anything and just let you have your way."

"But looking at it now, the Xu family is just a bottomless pit. Xu Guangyao¹ just isn't business material—their family company will go bankrupt sooner or later. It's better to withdraw early. What Zhou Yi'an can offer is much more than you imagine. If we can't get that piece of land in the south of the city, you..."

"What will happen?" Liang Shi interrupted her, asking coldly.

Qiu Zimin suddenly stopped.

She had never heard Liang Shi speak in such a tone before.

Usually, although this daughter had a bad temper, she was always obedient in front of her and never said a harsh word.

She frowned, "What kind of attitude is this?"

Liang Shi breathed out lightly, "What attitude do you think I should have?"

"Liang Shi, can't you just speak directly? Why do you have to be so sarcastic with your mother?" Qiu Zimin was also angry and said sternly, "You asked me to arrange this meeting, didn't you? So I arranged it. Even if you're not satisfied with Zhou Yi'an now, you don't need to take this attitude with me, do you? I've been doing my best to help you. I was the first to agree when you wanted to marry Xu Qingzhu. You're my daughter—how could I harm you?"

Liang Shi pinched her temples, "Yes, you wouldn't harm me."

It sounded calm but carried a hint of mockery.

Qiu Zimin answered confidently, "Of course not. You're flesh of my flesh—I'm the person who loves you most in this world. How could I harm you?"

"Is that so?" Liang Shi smiled sarcastically.

In the darkness, all emotions were infinitely magnified.

The complex emotions from the private room earlier all extended to this moment, transforming into anger.

"Don't you believe me?" Qiu Zimin laughed coldly, "Liang Shi, what's wrong with you? Why don't you even believe your mother's words? I've raised you for so many years—what did I do wrong to be treated like this by you?"

"Then do you know that Zhou Yi'an is an Alpha?" Liang Shi said coldly.

There were several seconds of silence on the other end of the phone.

Even the breathing stopped.

"I don't know," Qiu Zimin said.

Her tone was somewhat awkward.

"Then do you know that when two Alphas are together, one of them will get sick?" Liang Shi asked.

Qiu Zimin's end was silent again.

After a while, she said, "Of course I know, but what does this have to do with you?"

"What do you mean by introducing Zhou Yi'an to me?" Liang Shi said, "You know she likes me, so you want to use me to exchange for that piece of land in the south of the city? I really couldn't have imagined that I'm worth so much."

Qiu Zimin became anxious, "Ah Shi, your mother doesn't mean that. Alphas can be together too. Yi'an doesn't mind that you've had a marriage before, and you can become her lover. The most important thing for two people together is love. Your mother knows a doctor—there's now technology to change an Alpha into a Beta or Omega, and it doesn't harm the body."

"So you did know all along," Liang Shi said, "So your suggestion is for me to divorce Xu Qingzhu, undergo a differentiation surgery², become a Beta or Omega, and marry Zhou Yi'an. That way the Liang family can get that piece of land in the south of the city, right?"

Qiu Zimin's end fell silent.

A few seconds later, she hung up the phone.

Sometimes silence can represent many things.

Liang Shi emptied her mind in this endless silence, letting her thoughts drift freely.

After a while, she received text messages from Qiu Zimin:

【Ah Shi, if it weren't absolutely necessary, your mother wouldn't do this either. You know that among the four children, your mother loves you the most. No matter what you do, your mother always supports you the most. The Liang family's financial problems now are more difficult than you can imagine. After all, you've lived in this house for over twenty years—you're part of this family. Xinzhou and Xinhe have been working hard at the company, and Wanwan³ is still young. Now only you can help the Liang family get through this crisis. Just consider it your mother begging you. That piece of land in the south of the city determines the Liang family's life and death, and now you're the key. If you decide not to care, the Liang family might go bankrupt within two months, and then our whole family... never mind, pretend your mother didn't say anything.】

【Your mother was confused. Rest early, and next time you come home, your mother will apologize to you in person.】

Liang Shi read these two text messages expressionlessly and directly turned off her phone.

Qiu Zimin's words were actually very clear.

If she didn't marry Zhou Yi'an and get that piece of land in the south of the city, the whole Liang family would have to drink the northwest wind⁴.

At the end, she even used a strategic retreat⁵.

It seemed like she was backing down, but she was actually forcing Liang Shi to submit.

This kind of tactic didn't seem like it was being used for the first time.

The original body had probably complied before.

Because Liang Shi had a memory in her mind that was transmitted just as she was making the phone call.

In a dark room, the original body was wearing gauze clothing and tied to a bed. The gauze was almost transparent, and the person standing by the bed wore black leather clothing and held a whip. In the darkness, you couldn't see that person's face clearly, but the sound of the whip hitting flesh was very harsh.

The original body endured it without making a sound.

Liang Shi's hearing was tormented by that memory.

Fortunately, there weren't many such fragments.

In that memory, there was also Qiu Zimin's voice praising the original body: "Ah Shi did really well."

At the same time, Liang Shi was thinking about the scene just now—Zhou Yi'an had said "long time no see" to her.

So previously, the original body and Zhou Yi'an had known each other.

But Liang Shi had no idea how much interaction they'd had.

And Liang Shi suspected that Qiu Zimin should know that the original body wasn't her biological child.

That's why she would use such despicable methods to torment the original body.

Footnotes:

¹ **Xu Guangyao (許光耀)**: Xu Qingzhu's father, who apparently isn't good at business.

² **Differentiation surgery (分化手術)**: In ABO dynamics, a fictional medical procedure that can change someone's secondary gender (Alpha/Beta/Omega classification).

³ **Wanwan (晚晚)**: A pet name, likely referring to another sibling in the Liang family who is younger.

⁴ **Drink the northwest wind (喝西北風)**: A Chinese idiom meaning to have nothing to eat, to go hungry, or to be in dire financial straits.

⁵ **Strategic retreat (以退為進)**: A Chinese idiom describing a tactic where someone appears to back down or give up in order to actually achieve their goal by making the other party feel guilty or responsible.